

MIDDLEBURY FLAG FOOTBALL RULES 2026 (ver. 20260727)

Mission Statement: (*Safety, Sportsmanship and Fun*)

The Middlebury Flag Football program's mission is to teach basic football skills in a safe and competitive environment. Emphasizing full participation, team building, and sportsmanship, while developing the discipline required to be successful at the high school level of play.

Definition of Terms

1. MFF: Middlebury Flag Football
 2. Fumbles: Losing the ball after having possession.
 3. Muffs: The football falls through the kick returners arms, no possession of the ball is established.
 4. LOS: Line of scrimmage
 5. POI: Point of Infraction
1. **Field:** The flag football field measures 40 Yards by 80 Yards
 2. **Equipment**
 - a. Each player must wear: A helmet with a face guard, shoulder pads, mouthpiece, properly padded football pants, jersey with the color of their team, a belt with flags.
 - b. No shoes with metal cleats are permitted. Shoes with rubber cleats are okay.
 - c. No jewelry shall be worn by players during games.
 3. **Pregame activities**
 - a. Officials will conduct a check of equipment before the game and at the start of the second half.
 - b. Check that flags release properly, and jerseys do not cover the flags (flags must be easily accessible)
 - c. All players must start on either offense or defense.
 - d. Teams will have between 7 and 11 men on the field; each team must have the same number of players.
 4. **Game Time**
 - a. **Running Time-** Grades 7/8: 12 minutes running time during first and third quarters and the first 11 minutes of the second and fourth quarters. Exceptions: Officials or Team time outs.
 - b. **Running Time** Grades 5/6 10 minutes running time during first and third quarters and first 9 minutes of the second and fourth quarters. Exceptions: Officials or Team time outs.
 - c. **Running out the Clock:** Teams may end a half by "taking-a-knee" and running out the clock.
 - i. Coaches must inform the head official when they plan to run out the clock. The Officials will make the defense aware the offense is "taking-a-knee."
 - ii. The defense cannot rush the passer or penetrate the offensive line.
 - iii. Officials will stop the play upon the snap of the ball.
 - iv. If a Coach decides to resume normal play, then they must inform the head official. The officials will inform the defense normal play has resumed.
 - v. Failure to inform the Head Official the offense is resuming normal play will result in the Head Coach being penalized for unsportsmanlike conduct.
 - d. **Stop-Time: The final minute of the first half and the final minute of the game is "stop-time".**
 - i. The Game Clock is stopped at one minute, and both teams notified.
 - ii. There is No Stop-Time if one team is ahead by 18 or more points.
 - iii. The Head Official will manage the game clock during Stop-Time
 - iv. Thirty (30) Seconds is the maximum amount of time that can be run-off between plays.
 - v. In Stop-Time the Game Clock stops for:
 1. Incomplete passes
 2. Plays out of bounds.
 3. Touchdowns and Safeties
 4. Changes of possession
 5. On first downs, the clock stops until chains are reset.
 6. On kickoffs, the clock starts when the offensive team snaps the ball of the first offensive play.
 7. Accepted Penalties (The clock restarts if a penalty is declined.)
 8. Time Outs
 9. Officials Injury Time
 - e. **Half-time: A 5-minute break is taken between halves; there are no breaks between quarters**
 - f. **Time Out: Each team is allowed two 1-Minute time-outs per half. A player or coach may call time out.**

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- g. Injuries: When a player is injured the referee will stop the game.**
 - i. If the game is stopped, the injured player must leave the game for one play.
 - ii. During injury time both teams must stay on the field.
 - h. Play Clock for 7/8 30 Seconds. Play Clock for 5/6 45 Seconds**

Head Officials will announce when there are 10 seconds remaining on the play clock.

 - i. A first infraction will be warned; subsequent infractions are a 5 Yard penalty.
 - ii. Grades 5-6: After the ball is spotted, the offense will have 45 seconds to snap the ball.
 - iii. Grades 7-8: After the ball is spotted, the offense will have 30 seconds to snap the ball.
 - iv. 5th & 6th grade coaches may be on the field with their teams.
 - v. 7th and 8th grade coaches may be on the field during the first two games of the season.
- 5. Scoring and the 18 Point Rule**
- a. A Touchdown is six points,**
 - i. Scoring requires the ball and a player's flags to break the plane of the goal line.
 - b. Points After**
 - i. One point- A run or pass from the 2 ½ Yard Line
 - ii. Two points- A run or pass from the 5 Yard Line
 - c. A Safety is two points.**
 - i. Grades 7/8: After a Safety, the ball is placed on the 40 Yard line.
 - ii. Grades 5/6: After a Safety, the ball is placed on the 40 Yard line.
 - iii. *A safety requires the ball and the players flags to be in the end zone*
 - d. Grades 5/6 and 7/8: When a Team leads by 18 or more points the following rules are mandatory and implemented sequentially.**
 - i. *First rule: Defensive linemen are allowed to cross the line scrimmage 3 Seconds after the snap of the ball,*
 - ii. *If the winning team scores again, the losing team will have 5 downs to make a first down.*
 - iii. *If the winning team scores again the winning team will have 3 downs to make a first down.*
 - iv. *If the winning team scores again, the winning team must punt, or surrender the ball, on third down.*
 - e. The game clock does not stop if a team is ahead by 18 points. (Exceptions are for Injury or Official time outs)**
- 6. Playing Rules and Regulations**
- a. Official's whistle stops all plays.**
 - i. Inadvertent Whistle: If there is an inadvertent whistle, and a player's flags are still on, the offense has the choice to replay the down or resume play from the spot the runner had advanced when the whistle was blown.
 - b. Kickoff: Winners of the coin toss have a choice of kicking, receiving, or deferring to the second half.**
 - i. If the choice is deferred, the other team has the choice of kicking or receiving.
 - ii. Once the choice of kicking or receiving is made the other team chooses the goal line it wants to defend.
 - c. Touchbacks - On touchbacks the ball is placed at the 20 Yard line to start play.**
 - d. Ball Carriers: Stiff Arms, Out-of-Bounds, Loss of Flags, Falling, Advancement, Leaping**
 - i. The ball is placed at the spot where the flag is pulled.
 - ii. A stiff arm by a ball carrier is legal.
 - iii. If a foot, knee, or elbow lands in-bounds prior to a player going out of bounds, then the catch is in-bounds.
 - iv. A player may be pushed out of bounds if they are within 3-feet of the sideline.
 - v. If a ball carrier loses his flags without contact, the play is stopped when the ball carrier is touched by the defense.
 - vi. If a player's knee touches the ground, or he falls to the ground and his flags are on, he is down by contact.
 - vii. When advancement of a ball carrier is stopped, referees will stop the play.
 - viii. A ball carrier cannot leave their feet to advance the ball. The ball will be spotted where the runner leaves the ground.
 - ix. Whenever officials see ball carriers are in an unsafe position, play will be stopped.
 - e. Fumbles-**

5th and 6th Grade Level:

 - i. Fumbles on plays from scrimmage: The ball is dead and spotted where the fumble occurred.
 - ii. A dropped snap from Center is a fumble: The ball is dead and spotted at the line of scrimmage. This also applies to shotgun snaps.
 - iii. Any ball caught in the air (fumble or pass) is a live ball and may be advanced.

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7th and 8th Grade Level: Fumbles, Punt Snaps and Muffed kickoffs

- i. Fumbles on plays from scrimmage are live balls. They are recoverable by either team.
- ii. Dropped snaps from Center are fumbles. This also applies to “shotgun” snaps.
- iii. Any ball caught in the air (fumble or pass) is a live ball and may be advanced.
- iv. Muffs: On Kickoffs, a dropped ball is considered a “Muff. Only the receiving team may recover it.
 - a. The ball may not be recovered by the kicking team.
 - b. The receiving team can advance the ball after recovering a muffed kick.

f. Blocking:

- i. High school hand-contact rules apply (blockers must have open hands), no blocking below the waist or from behind. (Illegal block: 10 Yard penalty from LOS)
- ii. Double-team blocking is permitted either from a running or stationary position.

g. Player Substitutes: Unlimited substitution is allowed.

h. Weight restrictions: Athletes over 120 pounds (grade 5-6) or 150 pounds (grade 7-8) may not advance the ball as a running back or kick returner except under the 2 circumstances described below.

- i. Allowed: Players over 120/150 pounds may catch and advance a forward pass beyond the LOS or catch and advance an intercepted pass or fumble recovered in the air
- ii. Allowed: Players over 120/150 pounds may advance a ball kicked to them on the front line of a return kick-off team
- iii. **Quarterback Rule**: Any player over 120 pounds at the 5th-6th grade level and 150 pounds at the 7th-8th grade level, can play the quarterback position. The player is allowed to take the snap and either hand off the ball or make a pass. The player is NOT allowed to advance the ball. Advancing the ball will result in returning the ball to the LOS and loss of down. The player must wear a helmet cover to designate the player covered by the "quarterback rule". The offense must notify the head official the rule is being used and the head official will communicate this with the defense.

i. Sportsmanship- It is expected that coaches and players will consistently exhibit good sportsmanship.

7. Rules of Alignment: Offensive line, Defensive Line, Eligible Receivers, Ball Carriers

a. Offensive Line:

- i. The helmet of an Offensive Lineman must be aligned inside the waist of the center.
- ii. 7 to 10-man teams: Offenses are allowed a **maximum** of three players set off the line of scrimmage. The quarterback is counted as one of the three players allowed. All other offensive players must be on the line of scrimmage. (e.g., 8-man teams are required to have 5 players on the offensive line of scrimmage)
- iii. Linemen may not go more than 2 Yards beyond the LOS until the ball is passed (5 Yard penalty).
Exception: If the pass is completed behind the line of scrimmage.
- iv. Garbage Alignment Rule- There must be at least one lineman with a normal split (1-3 feet) on either side of the center. [Required: Guard-Center-Guard]
- v. Eligible Pass Receivers are the end players on the LOS and players in the backfield.
- vi. An offensive end can be hampered (jammed) within 5 Yards of the LOS

b. Defensive Line:

- i. The defense must have the following number of players on the defensive line.
Team-Size/Required number on Defensive Line: 7/3; 8/4; 9/4; 10/5
- ii. Linebackers must be 2 yards off the line of scrimmage.
- iii. *Nose tackles are not allowed to line up head up on the center.*

c. Rushing the Passer:

- i. Only players on the defensive line of scrimmage can rush the passer.
- ii. The maximum number of players allowed to rush the passer equals the number of players allowed on the defensive line of scrimmage.
- iii. The quarterback is considered a ball carrier once he breaks the 3-yard box on a roll-out.

d. Ball Carriers:

- i. Ball Carriers must line up behind the LOS.

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8. Kickoffs

- a. **5th and 6th Grade Level-** There are No kickoffs.
 - i. The first play of the game and first play of the second half starts at the 20 Yard line.
 - ii. Play starts at the 20-yard line after a score.
- b. **7th and 8th Grade:**
 - i. Kick-offs are from 30 Yard line. The Receiving team's front line must be between the 40 Yard line and their own 35 Yard line. They must remain in this zone until the ball is kicked.
 - ii. The Receiving team must have a minimum of five men on front line. (For 7-man teams, 4 men must be on the front line)
 - iii. There may be no player over 150 pounds behind the front line.

9. Punting

- a. **5th and 6th Grade Level-**
 - i. There is no punting at the 5/6 level.
 - ii. *In place of a punt, the ball will be moved 25 Yards down field.*
 - iii. The deepest the ball can be spotted is the opponent's 20 Yard line.
- b. **7th and 8th Grade Level**
 - i. *There is no punting at the 7/8 level.*
 - ii. *In place of a punt, the ball will be moved 30 Yards down field.*
 - iii. *The deepest the ball can be spotted is the opponent's 20 Yard line.*

10. Penalties

- a. All penalties will go through the head official.
- b. Enforcement of the penalty cannot take the ball more than ½ the distance to the goal line. A 10-yard penalty inside the 20-yard line is marked off as ½ the distance to the goal. Any penalty inside the 10-yard line is ½ the distance to the goal.
- c. Officials are encouraged to practice "preventive officiating." Examples: Warning players to get out of the neutral zone, informing coaches of movement before the snap of the ball, etc.
- d. Breakaway Rule: If in the official's judgement, an offensive or defensive player is tackled or held, and has obviously broken loose for an apparent touchdown, the ball will be spotted on the 1- yard line. Automatic first down.
- e. Side-line violation, Players and coaches may not stand on the sideline from the 20 Yard line to the goal line. After one warning a 5 Yard penalty from the LOS.
- f. Offensive Penalties:
 - i. Delay of game (e.g., exceeding huddle time, calling an extra timeout) 5 Yards LOS.
 - 1. One warning will be given for Delay of Game infractions.
 - ii. Off-sides: Crossing the line of scrimmage before the ball is snapped. 5 Yards LOS
 - iii. Illegal motion: Running back moves toward the LOS before the ball is snapped. 5 Yards LOS
 - iv. Illegal procedure: less than required number of players on LOS. 5 Yards LOS
 - v. Garbage alignment. [Required: Guard-Center-Guard] 5 Yards LOS.
 - vi. Ineligible man downfield. 5 Yards LOS
 - vii. Intentional grounding: 5 Yards LOS, loss of down
 - viii. Offensive holding: 10 Yards LOS **if penalty occurred behind LOS. 10 yards POI if the penalty occurred past the LOS.**
 - ix. Face Mask: 10 Yard penalty **POI.**
 - x. Offensive pass interference: 10 Yard LOS.
 - xi. Illegal forward pass. 5 Yards POI, loss of down
 - xii. Charging- ball carrier initiates contact with defender, (Especially prohibited - contact with helmet or shoulder pads). 10 Yards POI
 - xiii. Clipping/Block from behind: 10 Yards POI.
 - xiv. Guarding of flag or belt is spotted at the POI.
 - xv. *Ball carriers are not allowed to leave their feet to jump over a pile to advance the ball. POI, loss of down.*

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g. Defensive Penalties

- i. Missing the Flag: A player that attempts to pull a flag and misses, but subsequent action takes the offensive player to the ground. 5 Yards POI
- ii. Roughing the Passer: If a player attempts to block a pass and his momentum takes him into contact with the passer it is a tackle. 5 Yards LOS.
- iii. Face Mask: 10 Yard penalty LOS.
- iv. Pushing a runner out of bounds beyond the 3 Foot limit. (Tackle) 10 Yards POI
- v. Tackle- Any defensive action that intentionally takes a ball carrier to the ground. 10 Yards POI
 1. Degree of Tackle Infractions
 - Level 1 – Incidental: 5-yards
 - Level 2 – Intentional: 10-yards
 - Level 3 – Flagrant: 10-yards plus 10-yards for a Flagrant Tackle.
 - Level 4 – Repeated Flagrant: 20-yards for a Flagrant Tackle, plus removed from defense for 4 quarters.

Note: Officials will warn Coaches and Players subsequent Flagrant Tackles could result in disqualifications.

Examples of Illegal Tackles:

- Grabbing the jersey that stops forward progress.
- Intentional contact knocking a player to the ground and no attempt is made to pull the flag.

Legal Examples of stopping a ball carrier when the flags were not pulled:

- Pushing a ball carrier near the sideline out of bounds. (Less than 3 feet.)
- Getting blocked into the ball carrier and the ball carrier falls to the ground.
- Attempting to impede a ball carrier's progress to enable pulling a flag and the ball carrier falls to the ground.

h. Defensive pass interference

- i. The penalty is marked 10 Yards from the LOS.
- ii. If pass interference is inside the 10 Yard line or in the End Zone, the ball is spotted on 1 Yard line and automatic first down.

i. Kickoff- If a kickoff goes out-of-bounds, the receiving team has the following options:

- i. Re-kick with a 5 Yard penalty.
- ii. If the ball goes out of bounds between the goal line and 30 Yard line, the ball is placed at the 30 Yard line.
- iii. If the ball goes out of bound before reaching the 30 Yard line, it is spotted where it went out-of-bounds.

j. Unnecessary roughness (helmet slapping, unnecessary forearms.) 10 Yards POI.

- i. Players will be warned for the first infraction. Unsportsmanlike conduct could be called on a 2nd infraction (Referees Discretion)

k. Unsportsmanlike conduct: Coaches are encouraged to review this rule with parents and fans.

- i. Coaches are responsible for their own conduct, and the conduct of their players. Spiking the football, trash talking, throwing one's flags, swearing, altering a flag belt, hitting out of bounds, fighting, any behavior that is considered disrespectful to officials, opposing players, or coaches. 10 Yards **LOS**
- ii. Flagrant tackling and flagrant charging are unsportsmanlike. **10 Yards POI**
- iii. Officials may remove a player for a series of downs or eject a player from the game for unsportsmanlike Conduct. (Referees Discretion)
- iv. If a player receives 2 unsportsmanlike penalties in a game, or one infraction in two successive games, the player will be suspended from play for 4 full consecutive quarters from the point in time of the second infraction.
- v. A Coach penalized for Unsportsmanlike Conduct will be required to officiate a Flag Football game the following weekend.
- vi. If a coach is penalized for unsportsmanlike conduct twice in one game, or once in successive games, they will be suspended from coaching the next game.
- vii. Unsportsmanlike conduct of Fans:
 1. First Incident: Head Official asks the coach to speak to the fan.
 2. Second Incident: Head Official stops the game; Commissioner asks the fan to leave the premises. Game commences after the fan has left.

MFF Commissioner:

The commissioner will track players penalized for unsportsmanlike conduct and Flagrant Tackles

The commissioner can make temporary changes or modifications to these rules at his discretion.

Any permanent rule changes must be approved by the MFF Board of directors.

End of MFF Rules